

ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

FOR THE CAUSE OF LANGUAGE
CM Naveen Patnaik honouring eminent linguist Debi Prasanna Pattanayak at the conference in Bhubaneswar, Feb. 3

ODISHA

THE ODIA RENAISSANCE

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar *in Bhubaneswar*

An hour-long dance recital, choreographed by the renowned Aruna Mohanty. Even if the Biswa Odia Bhasa Sammilani was supposed to be about verbal language, it could not have asked for a more eloquent piece of self-expression. The gestural language of Odissi, thus, came to body forth the spirit of the first World Odia Language Conference, inaugurated by Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik in Bhubaneswar on February 3. It served as a testament to the resilience of the Odia people, depicting their ability to spring back—grace intact—from every challenge history threw at them. Throughout the three-day conference at the state capital's Janata Maidan, a recurring theme emerged: Odisha and its people have repeatedly risen like a phoenix from adversity, drawing strength from their language and culture—whether facing the might of British rule, tackling regional marginality or enduring repeated cyclonic devastations.

The language initiative of the Patnaik government, coming just months ahead of assembly election, is seen as a strategic step to elevate Odia pride and bolster the ruling Biju Janata Dal's identity as the champion of Odia language, culture and heritage.

In April 1936, after years of struggle, Odisha became the first Indian state to be formed on the basis of language. Seventy-eight years later, in 2014, Odia became the second language from the Indo-Aryan family after Sanskrit and the sixth Indian language to have been accorded classical language status. Ten years on, the first global Odia language conference paid tribute to this rich linguistic heritage.

While the event began with Patnaik honouring stalwarts of the language, such as the eminent 92-year-old linguist Debi Prasanna Pattanayak, who was instrumental in achieving the classical language tag for Odia, it concluded with him sharing the stage with children from various educational institutions. Also, a new keyboard debuted for the children, as part of an effort to facilitate the use of Odia in digital formats. "We respect our seniors. But language has to be put to use for the benefit of our children. They are our future and it is upon them to take our rich linguistic heritage forward," says R. Balakrishnan, the chief advisor (special initiatives) to Patnaik and the brain behind the event.

On the first day, Patnaik said his government would draw up a robust Odia policy, stressing the language's role as a unifier in the otherwise multilingual state, with robust Adivasi cultures cohabiting in the same space. The next day, the Jawaharlal Nehru University administration signed a memorandum of understanding with the state government to set up a special centre for teaching and research in Odia language, literature and culture, which will be named after Patnaik's father and former CM Biju Patnaik. The state has earmarked a corpus of Rs 10 crore for the initiative, which will be an upgrade of the current Adikabi Sarala Das Chair of Odia Studies at the New Delhi-based university. While the Sarala Das chair, opened in 2017, is engaged in research and propagation of the Odia language, the special centre will offer postgraduation and research programmes.

The government's resolve over the language's uplift can be gauged from the fact that the conference will be a recurring event. "This conference will remain a landmark. From here onwards, this festival will be held once every five years... I will announce our decision regarding the language in the assembly," Patnaik announced at the conclusion.